



BHASKAR PAUL

a meeting and were headed home when the first calls came. The first assessment: gang war shootout outside Leopold Cafe. As the attack escalated, officers rushed to the locations. Despite knowing that the terrorists were armed with AK-47s, the top brass of Mumbai Police hit the road with archaic weapons like carbines and 9mm pistols. The CST encounter is truly an Indian story. While Police Inspector Shashank Shinde was battling the terrorists, the railway police officials were not even armed. They had to rush to the weapons room to fetch their rifles. By the time they returned, the terrorists had killed 58 and Shinde was dead. Contrast this with the terrorists. Each carried a Kalashnikov, nine magazines with 30 rounds each, 150 spare bullets, nine grenades and a pistol with five magazines of 18 rounds each. And there were only 35 ATS members to deal with the enormity of the crisis. A 200-member commando force created in 1999 was disbanded by subsequent regimes.

The saga of equipment is a tragedy. Nearly 18 months back, P.S. Pasricha as director-general of police mooted upgrading of weapons. Thanks to the bickering between finance, planning and home departments, the proposal got "in-principle" approval last month. At this speed the police won't get their weapons till 2010. The .303 rifles are out of production, there is no ammunition produced and therefore cannot be tested in the firing range. In many cases the guns jammed too. At CST, Constable Ajit Kumar Nalavade took position behind the drinking water taps and fired three rounds at a terrorist before his carbine jammed. The bullet-proof vests

THE NSG OPERATION HAS RAISED QUESTIONS ABOUT TACTICS, TIME TAKEN, SCREENING OF ESCAPEES AND NON-USE OF GAS.

the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre if they had travelled just a few miles down, the naval installations or oil refineries in the western coast. Imagine the damage and the consequences.

Capability on ground zero is no better. When the terrorists struck almost simultaneously at three different locations, the Mumbai Police found itself battling the foes with pathetic leadership, poor coordination and outdated methods and weapons. There was poor assessment too. At around 9.15 p.m. on November 26, the Director-General of Police A.N. Roy, Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) chief Hemant Karkare and the Deputy Chief Minister R.R. Patil finished

worn by the officers also did not provide defence against AK-56 and AK-47 gunfire. In 2004, samples of these vests were sent to the firing range. Every bullet from SLRs and AK-47s went through the jacket even though the rounds were fired from a distance. Says former IPS officer Y.P. Singh: "More than Rs 100 crore is spent every year under the name of police modernisation but the jackets used are of very poor quality." If Nagappa Mali and his team did manage to nab the terrorists at Girgaum Chowpatty, it was providence and uncommon bravery as none of the cops wore bullet-proof jackets.

The gunning down of Karkare, Inspector